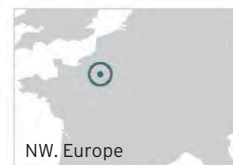




Musée d'Orsay

An architectural transformation of a former railway station into a museum known for its Impressionist paintings



△ CAST-IRON ARCHES

Laloux's magnificent great hall is now the main artery of the museum. Fittingly, it provides a wonderful setting for a wide range of artworks that were created during the heyday of the old Gare d'Orsay.

Situated on the Left Bank of the River Seine, the Gare d'Orsay was built in 1900 to cater to the huge influx of visitors expected at the Paris Exposition in the same year. It was the world's first all-electric rail terminal; because there was no steam circulating within, the architect, Victor Laloux, was able to house the station in a huge enclosed vault of iron and glass. Sadly, the station had a limited lifespan, as its platforms were short, and by 1939, it was only running suburban services. The threat of closure loomed large. There were plans to demolish the building and erect a hotel in its place. However, building permission was denied due to a public outcry, and the station was placed on the Inventory of Historical Monuments in 1973.

A new lease of life

While the station lay empty, it was used as a car lot, a film set, an auction house, and a theater. By the late 1970s, work on its transformation to

a museum was underway. An architectural firm, ACT Architecture, transformed the building, while the Italian architect and designer Gae Aulenti created the new interior. The museum was laid out on three levels. The great hall contains the central nave and the terraces on the mezzanine, which open out into further galleries at the side. The top level was installed above the lobby. The various levels were connected by glass walkways behind the main clock. Key features, such as the iconic clocks, were retained, while others were revamped. The decorative rosettes in the vault, for example, were turned into air-conditioning vents, while the station's former buffet has become a bookstore. The museum, which opened to the public in December 1986, focuses on artworks from 1848 to 1914, one of the most fertile periods in French culture. Uniquely, it encompasses all branches of the arts—painting, sculpture, photography, architecture, and the decorative arts.



△ TELLING TIME

The massive, Belle Époque clocks from the old station have become trademark features of the museum. This clock presides over the main gallery, while the glass on the facade provides spectacular views of Paris.